C2 Vocabulary

Metaphor in everyday English

Recognise the hidden metaphors behind common expressions and use them naturally in your own speech and writing.

Much ordinary English is built on a few big metaphors. Once you see the pattern, whole groups of expressions become easy to understand and remember, and you can use them with the right tone.

Metaphor	Expressions	Example
Argument is war	defend a position, attack a claim, win an argument, shoot down	*She shot down every objection in the meeting.*
Time is money	spend, save, waste, invest time; borrowed time	*We've invested a lot of time in this project.*
Ideas are food	food for thought, half-baked, digest, swallow	*It's a half-baked plan; I can't swallow it.*
Understanding is seeing	I see, shed light on, a clear view, in the dark	*The report sheds light on the causes of the crisis.*
Life is a journey	at a crossroads, a dead end, go off track, on the right path	*After ten years in banking, he felt he was at a crossroads.*

Extend the metaphor carefully. Staying inside one image sounds elegant: *We're at a crossroads, and the road ahead isn't clear.* Readers notice when the images fit together.

Common mistake. Mixing metaphors: *We'll cross that bridge when we've ironed out the bugs* joins a journey to a laundry and a computer. Keep to one image per sentence.

Practice

1. Which metaphor is behind "That's a waste of time"?

2. Complete: Thanks for the article; it gave me plenty of food for ___.

3. Replace with a seeing metaphor: The study helps explain why people move cities.

4. Fix the mixed metaphor: She attacked my argument and then digested it into pieces.

5. Describe someone unsure about their career, using a journey metaphor.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Time is money.
2. thought
3. The study sheds light on why people move cities.
4. She attacked my argument and then tore it to pieces. (Keep to the war image.)
5. For example: He's at a crossroads and isn't sure which path to take.